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Looking Ahead – a Bright Future for JQAS

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Abstract

The importance of sports statistics to professional sports teams is clear and there are exciting new opportunities for statisticians to learn from the new types of data that are collected. The Journal of Quantitative Analysis of Sports has shown steady growth since its inception in 2005. The new editorial system and new directions and initiatives of the journal are described.

The field of sports statistics has considerably matured in the last eight years. Many professional sports teams now have statisticians on their payroll, there are regularly-scheduled conferences devoted to sports statistics, and the *Moneyball* movie has recently demonstrated the value (to millions of viewers) of applying statistical methods to the drafting and utilization of players in sports. New types of data are being generated in sports, such as the PITCHf/x and FIELDf/x data in baseball, and the adjusted plus-minus data in basketball, and these new high-dimensional data provide exciting opportunities for statisticians to address a number of interesting questions in sports.

It is remarkable to observe the growth of the *Journal of Quantitative Analysis in Sports* in this period. JQAS began as an idea by Ben Alamar. In 2005, there were 32 manuscripts submitted, and submissions have steadily increased with 106 manuscripts submitted in 2011. All sports statistics researchers should be very appreciative of Professor Alamar for his efforts in creating the first journal dedicated to the statistical analysis of sports.

JQAS also has matured over the past eight years and currently provides a venue for statistics research over a wide variety of sports. Due to the efforts of the Section of Statistics in Sports of the American Statistical Association (ASA), JQAS is now an ASA official journal. In this transition period, JQAS is moving to a traditional editorial system where the Editorial Panel (group of Associate Editors) provides a more active role in the selection of referees and decisions on manuscripts. With this editorial system, authors can expect to receive solid, constructive advice on manuscripts in a timely manner, and the quality of accepted manuscripts should be high.

Now that JQAS is a well-established journal, there will be opportunities for special issues on topics of special interest. The journal will publish articles from presentations at sports statistics conferences such as the MIT Sloan Sports Analytics Conference. There are plans to have a special JQAS issue focused on golf – the PGA will be having a special golf research paper competition. The ShotLink Intelligence Prize competition challenges academics to find the best new application of ShotLink data to golf science. Other possible initiatives include articles on the use of sports in teaching statistics and a datasets section that introduces special sports datasets with invitations for statistical analyses from researchers and students.

In my six months as editor, I am very impressed with the submitted manuscripts describing interesting statistical analyses over a wide range of sports. In addition, I have been impressed with the hard work by all of the people that make the journal function – these people include the authors, the members of the Editorial Panel, and the many referees. Clearly, many people are passionate about sports and statistics and I expect JQAS to continue to grow as the leading outlet for statistics in sports research.